

Michael Wong

Professor Baker

ENC 1101-0001

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Major Project 1: Rhetoric in My Family's Kitchen

Kairos: My Mom's Cooking

Evidence: Photos 1-4 (uploaded privately in the Webcourses comments)

My mom doesn't cook on a schedule. She cooks when she feels like it, and on the other days I make my own food. I never know which kind of day it will be, so walking into the kitchen and finding her at the stove feels lucky.

Today was one of those days. She made a Peruvian dish with mixed seafood and rice. It gets its bright orange color from aji amarillo, an orange Peruvian pepper, and the kitchen smelled like a mix of herbs and spices.

College makes these days even rarer. When I lived at home, I got her cooking whenever she was in the mood. Now I leave UCF on Friday, stay home from Friday night through Monday, and head back Tuesday morning. That gives her only a few days to feel like cooking while I'm there. When she does, the meal means more to me because I know how easily I could have missed it. The kitchen gives me the most when the timing lines up, and I don't control the timing. That is the kairos of this space.

Identification: The Kitchen Table

Evidence: Photos 5-8 (uploaded privately in the Webcourses comments)

The kitchen table makes me part of my family. When the food is on the table and we sit down together, I eat as one of the family instead of on my own.

I can see this in the food. Our ancestry is Chinese, but a lot of my family lives in Panama, so we grew up with both cultures. My mom cooks Chinese food and Hispanic food, and both show up on our table. In Photos 1 and 6, you can see a bamboo steamer for Chinese food on the counter, in the same kitchen where she made the Peruvian dish. That mix is who we are, and we get the best of both. The Peruvian dish adds one more piece. We took a family trip to Peru last summer, so eating it brings back something we did together. Everyone eats the same meal at the same time. On the days I cook for myself, I eat whenever and wherever.

The chair in my photo is the one I always sit in. It's my spot at the table. Even though I'm at UCF most of the week, that chair is still mine when I come home, which shows I still have a place in the family.

Downs says things like “food and drink, furniture” can be actors in a rhetorical ecology (par. 29). The table, the chair, and the food shape what happens in the room. They give us a reason to sit in one place and spend time together, and that time is how we grow as a family.

How the Kitchen Shapes How I Feel About It

What I enjoy most about the kitchen is that it's like a blank canvas. I can make whatever I want, and since I enjoy food and cooking, it's where I get to practice. Looking at kairos helped me see this. On the days my mom doesn't cook, the kitchen is mine to use. On the days she does, I get to sit at the table and eat with my family.

There are parts I don't like. I love my dogs, but they always end up in the way whenever I'm making food. In Photo 5, one of them is lying under a chair at the table.

I also have mixed feelings about the size of the kitchen. A big kitchen gives me room to cook, but the bigger it is, the more cleaning there is to do.

Works Cited

Downs, Doug. "Rhetoric: Making Sense of Human Interaction and Meaning-Making." *Writing about Writing*, edited by Elizabeth Wardle and Doug Downs, 5th ed., Bedford/St. Martin's, 2022.